

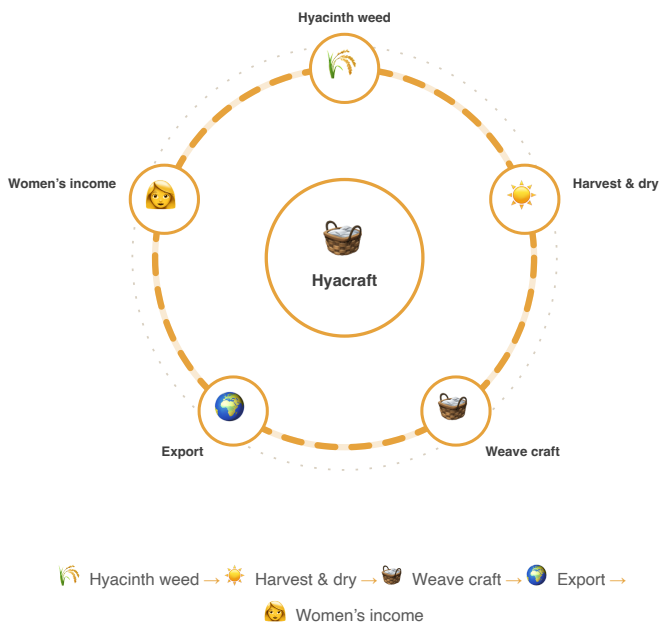
AGRI VALUE-CHAIN



# Hyacraft

## Hyacinth handicraft

*Bangladeshi women weave invasive water hyacinth into growing eco-friendly handicraft exports*



### THE SITUATION IN BANGLADESH

Introduced to Bengal from Brazil in the late 19th century, water hyacinth had clogged nearly all the region's waterbodies by the 1920s, obstructing river navigation and wetland cultivation <sup>1</sup>, and it remains a noxious invasive weed that today clogs rivers across Narayanganj, Narsingdi, Kishoreganj and Brahmanbaria, hampering boats and threatening fisheries <sup>1</sup>. The plant is among the world's fastest-growing, doubling its biomass in as little as 12 days, which is exactly why it overruns waterways while supplying an endless free raw material <sup>5</sup>. Yet in Kishoreganj's Kuliarchar and Narsingdi's Belabo upazilas, thousands of women now run and staff factories weaving this weed, hogla and jute into baskets and homeware <sup>2</sup>, part of a Bangladeshi handicraft sector that exported roughly US\$40 million worth of goods on a workforce of about 500,000 women, half of them working from home <sup>4</sup>. These home-based weavers can earn around Tk4,000–5,000 a month while still managing their households <sup>2</sup>, and the products already reach as many as 82 countries including the US and Canada <sup>3</sup>.

### OUR PITCH

Hyacraft turns Bangladesh's most damaging aquatic weed into export income by organizing a women's cooperative to harvest invasive water hyacinth and weave it into bags, baskets, furniture and mats <sup>23</sup> — taking nothing but a free, fast-regenerating material from clogged waterways <sup>5</sup> and converting it into eco-friendly handmade goods in proven demand across dozens of countries <sup>3</sup>. The wedge is a women-led, home-based labor model that already works at village scale in Kuliarchar and Belabo <sup>2</sup>, aligned with a US\$40-million national export sector built largely on half a million women weavers <sup>4</sup>. This is not a speculative leap: Vietnam's water-hyacinth craft has topped its handicraft export turnover and reached 163 countries <sup>7</sup>, and government-backed women's groups in the Philippines weave the same weed into bags, footwear and décor for income <sup>8</sup>, showing the model replicates. On sourcing, Hyacraft harvests from clean waters and uses stems and leaves rather than roots, because water hyacinth's roots concentrate heavy metals far more than its leaves (lead 5.45% in roots versus 0.66% in leaves) <sup>6</sup> — the same trait that lets the plant clean polluted water also guides safe, responsible material selection.

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